

Car Maintenance Guide

A complete guide to keeping your vehicle safe and reliable

1. Engine Oil

Engine oil is the lifeblood of your car's engine. It lubricates moving parts, reduces friction, and helps carry away heat. Change your car's engine oil every 5,000 to 7,500 kilometers, or as recommended by the manufacturer. Synthetic oils can often last longer than conventional oils, so check your owner's manual for the exact interval. Old, dirty oil loses its lubricating properties and can cause engine wear, increased friction, and reduced fuel efficiency. Always check the oil level using the dipstick when the engine is cool and the car is parked on level ground. Also inspect the oil's color and consistency; it should be amber and smooth, not dark and gritty.

2. Tyre Care

Proper tyre care improves safety, fuel efficiency, and extends tyre life. Check tyre pressure at least once a month, including the spare, using a reliable gauge. Under-inflated tyres reduce fuel efficiency, wear unevenly, and increase the risk of blowouts, while over-inflated tyres reduce grip and ride comfort. Rotate tyres every 8,000 to 10,000 kilometers to ensure even wear across all four tyres. Check tread depth regularly; replace tyres when the tread depth falls below 1.6mm, or sooner if you notice cracks, bulges, or uneven wear patterns. Also check wheel alignment periodically, especially after hitting a pothole or curb.

3. Brakes

Your braking system is one of the most critical safety features in your car. Listen for squeaking or grinding noises when braking, as this may indicate worn brake pads that need immediate attention. Have your brake fluid checked every 20,000 kilometers, as it absorbs moisture over time and can reduce braking performance. Brake pads typically need replacement every 30,000 to 70,000 kilometers depending on driving conditions and habits. If your car pulls to one side while braking, or if the brake pedal feels spongy, have the brake system inspected by a professional as soon as possible.

4. Battery

Car batteries typically last 3 to 5 years, depending on climate and usage. Clean corrosion off battery terminals regularly using a wire brush and a mixture of baking soda and water, then rinse and dry thoroughly. Ensure battery cables are tight and free of damage. If your car struggles to start, especially in cold weather, or if the dashboard battery warning light appears, the battery may need testing or replacement. Extreme temperatures, both hot and cold, can shorten battery life, so parking in shade or a garage when possible can help.

5. Air Filter

The engine air filter keeps dirt, dust, and debris from entering the engine, which is essential for proper combustion and performance. Replace the engine air filter every 15,000 to 30,000 kilometers, or according to the manufacturer's schedule. A dirty air filter reduces engine performance, fuel efficiency, and can cause the engine to run rough. In dusty or polluted environments, check and replace it more frequently. Don't forget the cabin air filter as well, which affects the air quality inside your car and the performance of the air conditioning system.

6. Coolant

The cooling system prevents your engine from overheating, especially during long drives or hot weather. Check coolant levels regularly using the markings on the coolant reservoir, and top up with the correct type of coolant if needed. Flush and replace coolant every 2 years or as specified by the manufacturer, since old coolant loses its protective properties and can cause corrosion. Never open the radiator cap when the engine is hot, as pressurized hot coolant can cause serious burns. Watch the temperature gauge while driving and pull over immediately if it rises into the red zone.

7. Wiper Blades

Clear visibility is essential for safe driving, especially in rain or snow. Replace wiper blades every 6 to 12 months, or sooner if they leave streaks, skip areas, or make noise on the windshield. Worn wipers reduce visibility during rain and can even scratch the windshield glass over time. Also keep the windshield washer fluid reservoir topped up, and clean the wiper blades occasionally with a soft cloth and mild soapy water to remove dirt and grime buildup.

8. Transmission and Fluids

Beyond engine oil, several other fluids keep your car running smoothly. Transmission fluid should be checked periodically and changed according to the manufacturer's schedule, typically every 60,000 to 100,000 kilometers for most vehicles. Power steering fluid, if applicable, should also be checked for proper level and clarity. Low or dirty transmission fluid can cause rough shifting, slipping gears, or overheating of the transmission system.

9. Lights and Electrical

Regularly check that all exterior lights are working, including headlights, tail lights, brake lights, and turn signals, as these are essential for visibility and communicating with other drivers. Replace any burnt-out bulbs promptly. Inspect fuses if any electrical component stops working suddenly. Keep an eye on the dashboard warning lights, and consult your owner's manual or a mechanic if any unfamiliar warning light appears.

10. General Tips

Keep a basic toolkit, spare tyre, jack, and jumper cables in the car at all times for emergencies. Follow the manufacturer's service schedule for regular inspections, even if the car seems to be running fine. Address unusual sounds, smells, vibrations, or dashboard warning lights promptly to avoid costly repairs.

later. Keep a maintenance log noting service dates and mileage, and wash and wax your car periodically to protect the paint and body from rust and corrosion.